AI LEADERSHIP PLAYBOOK

The Complete Guide

A comprehensive guide for broadband leaders
to understand, adopt, and leverage AI

CALIX INC

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Thank You For Exploring This Playbook

MODULE 1

INTRODUCTION

Understanding AI and Why It Matters

AI is already reshaping how communication service providers (CSPs) operate, compete, and serve their communities. But for most organizations, the challenge isn't access to AI—it's knowing where to start and how to lead the effort responsibly.

Module 1 builds the foundation. Before your organization can act on AI, your leaders and teams need a shared understanding of what AI actually is, how it applies to your business, and what it takes to adopt it with confidence.

Chapters in This Module

CHAPTER 1

Making AI Simple and Approachable

What AI really is, how it's already working in broadband businesses, and why the basics matter for your decisions.

CHAPTER 2

Three Initial AI Decisions That Will Set Your Course

The three early decisions—intent, platforms, and governance—that determine how fast and safely you adopt AI.

CHAPTER 3

Education & Enablement

How to build a practical AI education program that gives every employee the confidence to participate.

CHAPTER 4

Change Management

A five-step process for guiding your team through the transition to confident, responsible AI adoption.

CHAPTER 5

Activate Your AI Leadership Team

How to form a cross-functional AI leadership team with clear roles and a governance policy that fits your organization.

What You Will Learn

- Understand what AI is and how it is already working in broadband businesses
- Make the three early decisions that will shape your AI adoption
- Build an education and enablement program your teams will actually use
- Lead your organization through the change AI brings
- Stand up an AI leadership team with clear roles and a governance policy

What Success Looks Like

Organizations that complete Module 1 with confidence can usually say five things:

1. **Leaders share a common understanding of AI and its business relevance**
2. **Early AI decisions are defined—intent, platforms, and governance**
3. **Employees are informed, confident, and actively participating**
4. **A cross-functional AI leadership team is in place**
5. **A governance policy exists and is communicated across the organization**

> *The organizations that move farthest with AI are rarely the ones with the most technology. They are the ones that took the time to get their people, decisions, and leadership structure right from the start.*

MODULE 1

CHAPTER 1

Making AI Simple and Approachable

AI isn't science fiction. It's already part of everyday life. But what does it really mean for your business? Let's strip away the jargon and make AI simple.

This chapter introduces AI in practical terms, showing you what it is, how it's already working in your industry, and why understanding the basics helps you make smarter decisions for your business.

What You'll Learn

- What AI really is and what it isn't (debunking common myths)
- How AI is already working in broadband businesses like yours
- Why AI matters for your business, your team, and your customers

AI in Plain Language

AI is software that can learn from data provided to it and can help you make better decisions and automate tasks. Think of it as a digital assistant that gets smarter over time, helping you and your team work faster, smarter, and with more confidence.

In practical terms, there are two primary ways in which non-technologists will leverage AI for the foreseeable future:

Assistance

Copilot, ChatGPT, and Gemini are all examples of "AI-Powered Conversational Assistants," or as they are commonly known, AI Assistants. While they may resemble the old-style "chat bots" that have been around for a few years, these latest generation tools are far more sophisticated, leveraging large language models and other core AI features. However, in practice they fill the same need—intelligent entities we can talk to to augment our individual capabilities and become more effective.

Automation

This is how AI can help you streamline repetitive tasks and where agents come into play. Automation means letting AI agents handle routine work like summarizing notes, flagging issues, or sending reminders so your team can focus on higher-value activities.

In the broadband industry, these types of AI tools are already showing up in the technologies you use every day, from customer service to network monitoring tools. The key is to understand how these tools can help your business—not just what they do, but why they matter and how to make use of them.

Common Myths Debunked

Myth 1: AI will replace humans.

"Once we implement AI, we won't need as many employees."

Reality:

AI amplifies human capabilities—it doesn't replace judgment or creativity. The best results come when people and AI work together, for example, with humans setting direction and AI handling the heavy lifting.

Myth 2: AI is too complex for small businesses.

"We'd need data scientists and engineers to even get started."

Reality:

AI is already embedded in tools you use every day. You don't need a team of data scientists or AI engineers to get started. Most communication service providers can begin with the platforms and data they already have.

Myth 3: AI requires massive investment.

"We can't afford to implement AI right now."

Reality:

It's best to start small with existing platforms and scale gradually. Many AI features are built into the software you already use—like Microsoft Copilot, Salesforce, or Calix Cloud—so you can experiment and grow at your own pace.

Why AI Matters

When we focus on outcomes, AI is about making smarter decisions faster and in a more reliable and scalable manner—not chasing shiny tech. For broadband leaders, it can be a way to:

→ **Increase productivity:** Automate routine work so your team can focus on what matters most.

→ **Improve subscriber experience:** Use AI to personalize service and respond faster to customer needs.

→ **Stay competitive:** In a digital-first world, AI helps you keep pace with larger providers and deliver value to your community.

Chapter Takeaway

AI isn't about replacing your team or overhauling your business overnight. It's about taking practical steps to simplify operations, drive innovation, and grow your value with the team you already have.

MODULE 1

CHAPTER 2

Three Initial AI Decisions That Will Set Your Course

AI can be transformative, but only when it serves your strategy, not the other way around. The choices your leadership team make at the beginning of your AI journey will determine how effectively AI strengthens your operations, improves your customers' experiences, and drives sustainable growth for years.

This chapter helps you make three early decisions that will shape how fast, and how safely, you adopt AI across your business.

What You'll Learn

- How to define clear business intent by aligning AI adoption with specific operational challenges and measurable outcomes
- Strategies for selecting the right platforms that integrate with your existing systems and data infrastructure
- Best practices for establishing governance frameworks that ensure accountability, security, and ethical AI use
- Techniques for connecting each AI initiative to tangible business value and performance metrics

The Three Decisions

1. **Define Your Business Intent**
   Align AI adoption with specific operational challenges and measurable outcomes.

2. **Choose the Right Platforms**
   Select platforms that integrate with existing systems and keep data secure.

3. **Establish Governance, Security, and Accountability**
   Assign clear ownership and link every AI use case to business outcomes.

Decision #1: Define Your Business Intent

> *Start by asking yourself: "What are our intended outcomes with AI? What business problems will it solve?"*

Every successful AI program starts with clarity of purpose. The most effective leaders don't begin with "What can AI do?"—they begin with "What do we need to get better at?" When communication service providers (CSPs) define that intent clearly, AI stops being a shiny experiment and becomes a practical engine for performance.

Start With the Right Problems

In conversations with CSP leaders adopting AI today, the same themes come up again and again:

Today's Problems	How AI Can Help
"We spend too much time reacting to trouble calls."	Detect service or sentiment issues before they escalate—reducing truck rolls and inbound calls by up to 20%.
"Our frontline teams all do things differently."	Standardize performance with AI-driven call scoring and feedback—delivering a consistent, professional experience across every interaction.
"Managers waste hours reviewing random calls or reports."	Automate quality summaries so leaders focus on coaching and development, not monitoring.
"Subscribers only call when they're frustrated."	Predict churn risks with AI sentiment analysis and trigger timely outreach before frustration turns into a cancellation.
"Sales performance is uneven."	Coach every rep using insights from high-performing conversations—AI analyzes tone, pacing, and phrasing to replicate success.
"We have data everywhere but can't see the big picture."	Connect your systems so AI surfaces actionable insights automatically—eliminating manual data pulls and fragmented reporting.

Examples From the Field

EXAMPLE 1

One CSP discovered that customers were having dramatically different experiences depending on which agent answered a customer's call. After implementing AI call analysis tied to their standard procedures, they could finally see and fix those inconsistencies in real time.

EXAMPLE 2

Another company re-tasked quality-control staff from listening to random recordings to creating proactive training videos, using AI to summarize 100% of calls automatically. The outcome wasn't job reduction—it was job elevation.

Key Insights

Teams began flagging missed opportunities like failing to mention autopay or online payment portals. Instead of waiting weeks for coaching, reps saw instant, objective feedback that helped them self-correct.

Some providers now use AI to monitor sentiment. If a conversation goes in the wrong direction and the problem isn't resolved within a few hours, AI can trigger an outreach to that customer, converting potential churn into loyalty.

AI analysis also showed that small word choices mattered. Swapping "big antenna" for "simple outdoor receiver," for example, improved close rates. The intent wasn't automation; it was better communication.

Patterns Behind Effective Intent

Across these examples, the clearest intents share five traits:

→ **Efficiency** — Buy back time so people can focus on higher-value work

→ **Consistency** — Deliver the same great experience every time

→ **Proactivity** — Solve problems before subscribers feel them

→ **Professionalism** — Raise the standard of every interaction

→ **Personalization** — Tailor support and offers to each customer's reality

This is how you turn AI from a "shiny object" to a strategic lever, one that aligns with your company's mission and helps you deliver measurable value.

Decision #2: Choose the Right Platforms

> *The next key question you should ask yourself is: "Where and how will we activate AI to solve those business problems?"*

Once you know why you're adopting AI (Decision #1), the next question is where to bring it to life (Decision #2).

For most broadband providers, AI should be leveraged via the platforms you already use every day: your productivity suite, CRM, billing system, support tools, and Calix Cloud. The smartest place to start is where your data already lives driving incremental, but meaningful gains, across your company, not in a single "moonshot" project.

Guidelines for Choosing Wisely

✓ **Select a trusted platform** that fits your data, security, and operational model. Don't reinvent an AI stack, leverage the one you have

✓ **Leverage AI-native tools** such as Microsoft Copilot, Workday, or Calix Cloud that include built-in governance, auditability, and enterprise-grade security

✓ **Confirm data readiness.** AI is only as good as the data it can see. Ensure that information is accurate, accessible, and compliant so models generate reliable insights

✓ **Respect governance boundaries.** Your security, compliance, and privacy policies already govern the platforms you use today, so keep AI activity inside those same security boundaries

One example of a trusted platform you use today is Calix Cloud. Starting your AI journey within Calix Cloud keeps AI innovation inside a secure, well-governed environment, one designed specifically for communication service providers.

It means your network, marketing, operations, and support data stay connected under a single policy framework, letting you:

— simplify daily operations

— accelerate insight-driven decision-making

— scale AI safely as your company grows

This approach transforms AI from a daunting experiment into a simple extension of your existing systems, helping you move faster without losing control of the guardrails that protect your business and your subscribers today.

Decision #3: Establish Governance, Security, and Accountability

AI adoption needs clear ownership from the beginning. Assign a small group, or even just one or two people, to guide AI adoption, set guardrails, and measure results.

Their focus should be on:

- Defining standards for ethics, privacy, and security
- Deciding when tools are ready to deploy broadly
- Linking every use case to measurable business outcomes

Clear ownership builds trust, speeds adoption, and ensures successful AI adoption.

> **Note:** Governance is so important it will be covered in Chapter 5 "Activate AI Leadership Team" and Chapter 10 "AI Governance Goes Mainstream."

Chapter Takeaway

Focus on leveraging the AI capabilities within the platforms you already trust and use the three key decisions set out in this chapter to frame out your early adoption of AI.

MODULE 1

CHAPTER 3

Education & Enablement

One of the key lessons that has emerged from those companies on the leading edge of AI adoption has been that preparing your employees to be ready for and able to use AI is vital to successful adoption.

The companies that have been successful have shown that a robust program of education and enablement for your employees is a requirement, not an option. Simple AI orientation meetings will not get the job done.

What You'll Learn

- What the goals of education and enablement are
- Some key roles to target
- How to leverage your key partners
- Why and how to engage your full community
- How to build a simple but valuable program on a budget

Why Education & Enablement Matter

AI adoption, like all technology adoption, succeeds or fails on the basis of one key factor: people. Even with the right strategy, platforms, and governance, progress stalls if teams aren't mentally and practically ready to work with AI.

Education and enablement are about building confidence in your employees, not just compliance with the rules. They focus on helping every employee understand why change is happening, what it means for them, and how they can actively participate.

Practical Steps To Launch Your Program

Follow these steps to build momentum and ensure your AI education program delivers real results.

1. **Assess Readiness:** Survey your teams to identify their knowledge gaps and concerns.
2. **Map Training to Personas:** Align content and delivery with the needs of each role leveraging AI.
3. **Leverage Existing Resources:** Use internal platforms and vendor offerings to avoid duplication.
4. **Track Progress:** Integrate learning milestones into team meetings and development plans.
5. **Celebrate Success:** Recognize individuals and teams who embrace AI and share their wins.

Building Your AI Education Program

A successful AI adoption strategy requires education at every level—from frontline teams to executives—and extends beyond your organization to include partners, customers, and the broader community you serve. The good news? You don't need a massive budget to make it happen.

Focus on three practical delivery methods that don't require a large budget:

→ **Microlearning** — Short 5- to 10-minute modules that fit busy schedules

→ **Peer-Led Training** — Empower early adopters to share tips with colleagues

→ **Vendor Resources** — Leverage materials from partners like Calix University

The matrix below shows how to match these formats to the right topics and audiences.

Training Topic	👥	💻	👔

	Frontline Teams	Technical Teams	Leadership
AI Fundamentals Core concepts & safe use	Essential Microlearning + Vendor	Essential Microlearning + Vendor	Essential Vendor Resources
Role-Specific Applications AI tools for daily workflows	Essential Peer-Led + Vendor	Essential Vendor Resources	Recommended Vendor Resources
Integration & Data Readiness Deployment & security	Recommended Peer-Led	Essential Peer-Led + Vendor	Recommended Vendor Resources
Governance & Strategy Adoption & measuring impact	Recommended Microlearning	Recommended Peer-Led	Essential Vendor Resources

Best Practice: Leverage Key Partners

Include your key partners in your education and enablement initiatives, whether they're technology vendors, consultants, or ecosystem collaborators. Calix is one prime example of such a partner, but it's certain you have others that you can and do rely on. Leverage these key partners in this work as they are undoubtedly on a similar journey and would be eager, as Calix is, to help you in any way they can. This ensures all of your key business and technology partners are aligned and working together for you on best practices, security, and shared outcomes.

AI Readiness Self-Assessment

This self-assessment is a short, reflective activity designed to help you pause and take stock of where you currently stand with AI at work. Rather than testing right or wrong answers, it explores your familiarity with common AI tools, your comfort level using them, and your curiosity about applying AI in real workplace situations.

SELF-ASSESSMENT TOOL

AI Readiness Self-Assessment

This short activity will give you insight into where you are on your AI journey — and how to make the most of this training.

1. **Complete the Self-Assessment**
   10 questions · ~3 minutes
2. **Receive Your AI Persona**
   One of 4 profiles matched to you
3. **Get Personalized Learning Tips**
   Curated for your starting point

Begin Assessment →

Ready-to-Use Training Resources

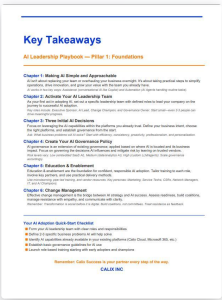
You don't have to build your AI education program from scratch. Below are three foundational resources you can use right away to jumpstart your team's AI fluency—a self-assessment to surface where each person stands, a glossary to establish shared vocabulary, and a microlearning course to build core understanding. Share these with your team to create a common starting point for your AI journey.

PDF DOWNLOAD

Essential Terms & Definitions

A printable glossary covering key AI concepts, terminology, and definitions. Use this to help your team build a shared vocabulary around AI.

Download PDF



MICROLEARNING COURSE

Understanding Artificial Intelligence and Machine Learning

In just a few minutes, learners will explore what AI actually is, where it shows up in everyday life, and how it differs from human intelligence.

🎓 Launch Course

These resources are just the beginning. As your team grows more confident with AI fundamentals, you can expand your training library to address role-specific applications and advanced use cases. The key is to start now—every step forward builds momentum for your organization's AI journey.

Chapter Takeaway

The education and enablement you give your people can be the foundation for confident, responsible AI adoption across your company. By tailoring training to each role, involving key partners, and using practical delivery methods, you can empower your company to move from awareness to mastery—turning AI from a source of anxiety into a driver of innovation and value.

MODULE 1

CHAPTER 4

Change Management

Here's news that will not surprise you: AI has the power to change your company in profound ways. Here's more news that won't surprise you: When anything threatens to change your company in profound ways, you need to put in place a program of change management to help your employees, your leadership, and you through that change successfully.

In the prior chapter we talked about the table stakes of change management—education and enablement. Now we dig in more deeply on what's required to lead your team through the transition to robust AI adoption and accelerated business growth.

What You'll Learn

- Why change management is vital to successfully adopting AI
- A simple five-step process for building an effective change management program

Preparing People To Work Confidently With AI

The flip side to the fact that AI has the potential to improve every role in your company is that AI has the potential to change every role in your company, and, as we know, change is not something people uniformly embrace. What's key, therefore, as you introduce AI into your company, is effective change management.

Change management isn't about controlling your people, it's about creating confidence in them. When done correctly, it helps every employee understand why change is happening, what it means for them, and how they can actively participate in it.

1 Assess and Build People Readiness

One mistake organizations often make when building a change management program is focusing too much on the goal or destination rather than the starting point. In other words: where are your people now? Effective change management begins by understanding your current state and meeting people where they are.

Another best practice is for leaders driving the initiative to model vulnerability and honesty. Admitting you don't have all the answers invites curiosity instead of fear and helps build genuine trust. It's important to remember that transformation is social before it is digital. Culture shifts happen when leaders communicate openly and create space for experimentation and play.

A practical way to understand your starting point is through employee surveys and focus groups. These can help uncover attitudes toward AI, as well as areas of uncertainty or concern, before change efforts begin. You can also leverage tools like the self-assessment introduced in Chapter 3 to give individuals a structured way to reflect on their current familiarity, comfort, and curiosity with AI in the workplace.

Remember: The goal isn't to eliminate discomfort, it's to acknowledge it and give it purpose through the context of the changes being undertaken.

2 Build Coalitions, Not Committees

Successful change spreads through relationships, not mandates. Identify a cross-functional AI Champion network with early adopters from across your company such as customer service, network operations, field technicians, sales, finance, or other departments that reflect your company's structure.

→ Give these champions early access to AI tools and learning resources.

→ Encourage them to share success: "What got easier this week because of AI?"

→ Empower them to raise obstacles quickly so issues are solved in real time.

To take this further, see Chapter 5: "Activating Your AI Leadership Team," where you'll learn how to formalize and scale this coalition into a sustained leadership capability.

Key Insight: Coalitions create cultural pull. People will follow peers who model what's possible.

3 Manage Resistance With Empathy and Evidence

Resistance isn't opposition; it's information. When employees hesitate, it's usually the result of one of three things:

- **Fear of loss:** "Will AI replace what I do best?"
- **Lack of clarity:** "How does this fit into my day-to-day work?"
- **Lack of confidence:** "Do I have the skills to use this responsibly?"

Address each of these issues with empathy and evidence:

✓ Reinforce that AI assists people, it doesn't replace them.

✓ Share real examples of productivity or service improvements.

✓ Offer hands-on, role-based training so confidence grows alongside capability (e.g., by leveraging Calix Education modules).

> **Key Insight:** Treat resistance as feedback helping you refine and improve your change management program and, as always, celebrate the gift of feedback.

4 Leverage Existing Learning Modules

An easy example of valuable training material from a trusted external source is the Calix Education & Success Portal. Below are examples of materials you can use to align learning tracks with each stage of AI adoption within your company. The goal is to help teams move from awareness to confident application one step at a time.

Phase	Learning Module	Example Module
Awareness	"What AI is and why it matters"	Leading AI-Empowered Teams 🔗 Available Now
Activation	"Using AI in daily workflows"	Calix Cloud AI Capabilities Coming Soon
Adoption	"Driving results through data"	Applied AI for Customer Experience Coming Soon
Expansion	"Coaching with AI insights"	AI-Powered Performance Coaching Coming Soon

One effective tactic to increase the uptake of this kind of training is to bake it into the normal workings of your company. For example, integrate each learning phase into regular team meetings, manager check-ins, or quarterly development plans so learning becomes part of the rhythm of the company, not a one-time event. When you do this, training progress can serve as a leading indicator of adoption readiness.

5 Communicate With Clarity and Cadence

People's fear of change is one thing, and we've discussed that above, but that fear can be made even more pronounced if there is confusion that goes along with it. A good communication plan around the adoption of AI will provide clarity, consistency, and a cadence that will reduce the fear of change across your employee base.

Clarity

Always explain the why behind each change. Tie updates back to business intent and subscriber value.

Consistency

Use unified language across leadership messages, internal posts, and meetings.

Cadence

Communicate early, often, and again after milestones are achieved.

Create a two-way dialogue with your employees through Q&A sessions, office hours, or community forums. Again, welcome the gift of feedback.

Chapter Takeaway

Effective change management is the bridge between AI strategy and AI success. By assessing readiness, building coalitions, managing resistance with empathy, leveraging existing learning resources, and communicating with clarity, you can guide your team through the transition to confident AI adoption.

MODULE 1

CHAPTER 5

Activate Your AI Leadership Team

AI will soon be built into the same Calix Cloud applications (Engagement Cloud, Operations Cloud, and Service Cloud) that already run your core business.

When that happens, you'll have access to a complete AI-enabled platform from a trusted source ready to leverage to incorporate AI into your core business processes. To make the three initial decisions referenced in Chapter 2, you will need an AI leadership team to determine how these new capabilities will be used day-to-day: which problems to solve first, how to measure results, and how to keep adoption consistent across teams. Additionally, your AI leadership team needs to establish an AI governance policy as you begin your AI adoption journey.

What You'll Learn

- Why setting out an explicit AI leadership team is vital
- What roles are key to that team
- The various levels of complexity that exist in implementing AI
- How to govern the risk AI introduces at each of those levels
- How to create an AI governance policy that fits the unique needs of your company

Platforms Provide Power; Leadership Decides Where To Focus It

An AI leadership team keeps things organized and intentional. It ensures every AI effort supports clear business goals, saving time, improving the subscriber experience, or easing the load on staff, instead of becoming a one-off experiment.

Because governance is a leadership responsibility, this group also defines how AI tools will be tested, approved, and introduced to employees across the company. They set practical boundaries for what should stay in human hands versus what can be automated, share what's working, and build confidence through communication and hands-on learning. Resources like Calix U's AI-Empowered Workforce Evolution program make that curated rollout of AI easier to scale.

When Forming Your Team

- ✓ **Start small.** Even two or three people can drive meaningful progress.
- ✓ **Choose cross-functional members.** Include voices from operations, marketing, and customer service.
- ✓ **Assign clear roles.** Define who leads, who coordinates, and who reports back.

Key Roles To Consider

👤

Executive Sponsor

Champions AI at the leadership level and secures resources.

🎯

AI Lead

Coordinates day-to-day efforts and tracks progress.

💡

Change Champion

🛡️

Governance Owner

Drives adoption and addresses team concerns.

Ensures ethical, transparent, and responsible use.

Create Your AI Governance Policy

Strengthen What Exists — Extend Where Needed

Your governance policy for AI is one of the key decisions your AI leadership team needs to make as you begin your AI adoption journey.

For most communication service providers, the AI most used by its employees will appear inside the trusted platforms they already count on, e.g., Microsoft 365, Salesforce, Calix Cloud. These platforms come with enterprise-grade security, privacy, and compliance controls baked in. That means governance isn't something new to build; it's something to review, reinforce, and communicate.

However, in the situations in which a broadband provider is aggregating data for analytics or introducing stand-alone AI tools or home-grown applications that operate outside those environments, different levels of work and oversight are required. Each level of complexity raises the risk level, requiring deeper governance measures.

AI Location	Examples	What You Govern	Complexity Level	Governance Approach
Trusted Applications With Built-In AI	Workday, Salesforce Einstein, ServiceNow AI	Usage configuration, access, enablement decisions	**Low – Medium**	Policy + Procurement Controls
AI in Data & Analytics Platforms	Snowflake Cortex, Databricks Models	Training data, performance, explainability	**Medium – High**	Model Governance + Data Governance Integration
Custom, LLM, Agent AI	OpenAI API, Azure OpenAI, Internal Chatbots, RAG Systems	Prompts, model outputs, hallucination behavior, safety	**Highest**	Full AI Risk Management + Human Oversight

> It's very important to recognize that not all AI requires heavy governance. The most important thing is to govern the risks AI introduces, not the technology itself.

Apply Governance Differently Based on Where the AI Lives

Trusted Applications With Built-In AI LOW COMPLEXITY

Modern examples: Workday, Salesforce, and ServiceNow

When you're working with AI embedded in vendor applications, you rarely govern the model itself. Instead, you are governing how your company uses it. This significantly lowers the inherent risk and complexity of governance. In this case your controls are:

- ✓ Contract Language
- ✓ Enable/Disable features by policy
- ✓ Access rights (which roles see AI suggestions)
- ✓ Documentation of business impact
- ✓ Audit logs for decisions influenced by AI
- ✓ Acceptable Use Policies

AI built into enterprise applications should fit within existing application governance practices. It is wise to ensure contractual language addresses the need to protect your company's data, including the prompts submitted to AI systems and the responses to those prompts. You should ensure accurate access controls are in place as many employees have a tendency to overshare content, and AI may surface or reference confidential information if it isn't protected to begin with.

Educate your employees on responsible use of AI, e.g., that they are ultimately responsible for the output they share whether they use AI or not. Update your company's Acceptable Use Policies if needed to ensure employees know AI is there to assist, but ultimately they are responsible for its proper use.

> **Think of It This Way:** Treat AI like the power tools you find around your garage—safe if used correctly, dangerous if mishandled! As long as employees know their accountability, no committees or bureaucracy is required, just explicit human accountability.

AI in the Data/Analytics Layer MEDIUM COMPLEXITY

Modern examples: Snowflake Cortex and Databricks

Where you are aggregating data from multiple sources for analytics, your risk and complexity grow because this is where insights start influencing decisions. You are no longer relying on access controls on source systems like Salesforce or Microsoft 365; you now have to consider additional controls:

- ✓ Data handling standards DATA GOVERNANCE
- ✓ Privacy Assessments DATA GOVERNANCE
- ✓ Data lineage DATA GOVERNANCE
- ✓ AI-generated insights should require peer reviews AI GOVERNANCE
- ✓ Automated Decisions must be manually approved AI GOVERNANCE
- ✓ Fairness and bias checks AI GOVERNANCE

This is where data governance and AI governance must be integrated. Where AI output is used to drive decisions, you require continuous monitoring and explainability. For anything that changes behavior broadly (pricing, staffing, customer targeting), ensure someone accountable carefully reviews it.

Custom AI/LLM/Agent Systems HIGH COMPLEXITY

Modern examples: OpenAI, RAG, and internal copilots

When you are planning to build custom AI capabilities, here again the risk grows along with the need to apply the full governance stack because outputs can vary by prompt and context, models may hallucinate, and model behavior can change over time. With these challenges come additional control requirements:

- ✓ Prompt filtering and safety guardrails
- ✓ Human in the loop for high-impact actions
- ✓ Output logging and traceability
- ✓ Clear rollback and shutdown procedures

This is your highest risk, and therefore, strictest governance situation. In this case, it is recommended that you carefully inventory and manage each AI instance along with its interactions with other agents and tools.

Chapter Takeaway

As your first act in adopting AI, set out a specific leadership team with defined roles to lead your company on the journey to successful AI adoption.

AI governance is an extension of existing governance, applied based on where AI is located and its business impact. For most broadband providers, focus on governing the decisions AI influences and mitigate risk by leaning on vendors like Calix who lower your risk profile.

MODULE 2

INTRODUCTION

Get Started With Calix Agent Workforce Cloud

AI delivers value only when it's applied to real business problems. At this point in history, the question is no longer what AI can do. It's where it should be used first, and whether your organization is ready to support it.

In Module 1, the focus was awareness and shared understanding. This module moves the conversation forward. The goal now is readiness and practical activation.

Chapters in This Module

CHAPTER 6

AI Is Really a Change Initiative

Why AI results depend far more on people, process, and leadership alignment than on technology.

CHAPTER 7

Data Quality as the Force Multiplier Across the AI Journey

How clean, connected data transforms AI from a source of confusion into a driver of confident decisions.

CHAPTER 8

Where To Start With the Agent Workforce Cloud

Where to activate AI agents first to drive measurable business impact across the organization.

What You Will Learn

- Recognize why AI adoption is primarily an organizational change effort
- Evaluate your organization's readiness in practical terms
- Strengthen the data habits that make AI trustworthy and reliable
- Identify where the Agent Workforce Cloud can create real impact
- Prioritize next steps with confidence

What Success Looks Like

Organizations that are ready to scale AI can usually say five things with confidence:

1. **Executive alignment is in place**
2. **Data is clean enough to trust**
3. **Governance is clear and understood**
4. **Teams know what is changing and why**
5. **Key metrics are defined and AI initiatives are tied to outcomes**

> *If one or more of these feel uncertain, that is normal. By the end of this module, you should have a clear picture of where your organization stands today and where to focus first.*

MODULE 2

CHAPTER 6

AI is Really a Change Initiative

AI often enters the conversation as a technology topic. In practice, the results depend much more on people, process, and leadership alignment.

The providers seeing the strongest results treat AI as a business initiative—using it to improve how work gets done across the organization. This chapter explores why organizational readiness matters more than technology sophistication, and how to assess whether your teams, data, and processes are prepared to support AI-driven change.

What You'll Learn

- Why AI adoption is primarily a business and change initiative—not a technology deployment
- How to recognize where "silo friction" can limit AI's impact across your organization
- How to assess your organization's readiness across leadership, data, and change management
- Which management habits allow AI to deliver measurable, lasting value

People Strategy Versus Technology Strategy

Recent research shows a consistent pattern. Organizations that approach AI as a people and process strategy outperform those that treat it mainly as a technology deployment. Most AI efforts do not stall because the models fail. They stall because the organization is not ready to change how work is conducted.

COMMON APPROACH

AI as an IT Rollout

Treated as a technology project. Stays small, experimental. Lacks clear ownership or business metrics. Teams remain unchanged.

vs

HIGH-IMPACT APPROACH

AI as a Business Initiative

Tied to a real performance gap. Clear ownership, clear measures. People and processes evolve alongside the technology. Adoption accelerates.

When AI is treated like an IT rollout, it tends to remain small and experimental. When it is tied to a real performance gap—with clear ownership and measures—adoption accelerates. The difference is not the technology. It is the organizational context surrounding it.

Where AI Efforts Commonly Stall

If the technology is rarely the bottleneck, what is? In most broadband organizations, friction comes from the human and structural side of the equation. Here are the most common friction points that prevent AI from gaining traction:

Teams Don't Trust the Outputs

When teams can't see where AI recommendations come from, they fall back on familiar, manual decisions.

Workflows Remain Unchanged

AI is layered on top of existing processes instead of being integrated into redesigned workflows—creating extra steps rather than removing them.

Data Stays Fragmented

Critical data lives across disconnected systems. Without a unified view, AI can only optimize pieces of the puzzle—not the full picture.

Ownership is Unclear

No single team owns the end-to-end journey. Without clear accountability, AI improvements stall between departments.

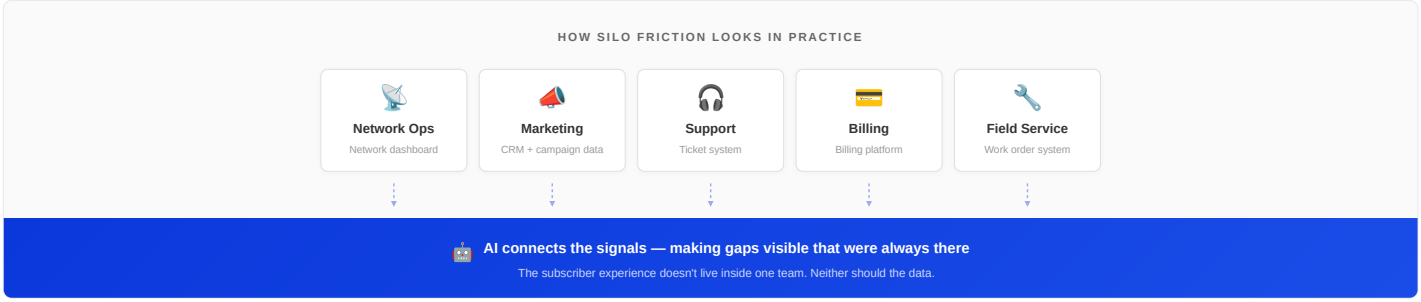
> **The Pattern:** When AI is treated like a technology project, it stays small. When it is tied to a real business outcome—with clear ownership and measures—adoption accelerates and results follow.

Optimizing the End-to-End Subscriber Journey

One of the first things AI exposes inside most broadband organizations is fragmentation. AI agents naturally cut across traditional boundaries, including sales, services, network operations, and back office. This is where "silo friction" shows up. Each team has its own tools, data, and priorities, so the signals needed to manage the subscriber experience are scattered. As AI begins connecting those signals, gaps that were always present become visible—and harder to ignore.

Where Silos Typically Appear

Most organizations have been designed around a command-and-control structure that optimizes work through functional silos with deep expertise. While this structure is effective for scale and control, rarely does any single team have visibility across the end-to-end customer journey. The result? Breakdowns that are invisible to any one department but painfully obvious to your subscribers:



Redesigning against the customer journey exposes one of the most significant change management challenges leaders face: dismantling silos that were never designed to operate as a single system. Instead of asking, "How do we optimize one team's metrics?", high-performing providers ask, "Where does the subscriber experience break down, and how do we catch it earlier?"

Why Journey Thinking Matters

Customers struggle to navigate the inherent delays, friction, miscommunication, and botched handoffs that occur as they interact with your company. They do not care which department owns a particular step—they care whether the experience works. When leadership, data, and processes are aligned on creating a seamless and friction-free experience, it often unlocks meaningful progress that no single team could achieve on its own.

> **Key Insight:** AI does not create silos—but it does make them visible. Use that visibility as a catalyst for the cross-functional alignment your subscriber experience has always needed.

Is Your Organization Ready for AI?

As noted earlier, AI is primarily a change initiative. To successfully implement and scale AI, strong leadership teams assess readiness across three areas. Each one can either accelerate or stall your progress—and the honest assessment of where you stand is more valuable than any technology evaluation.

1 Executive Alignment

> *What problem, if reduced by 20–30%, would most impact outcomes for your organization this year?*

Start with this simple question. Common high-impact problems include declining monthly revenue per subscriber, rising churn risk, growing operating expenses, and slow detection of network issues. Executive alignment means leadership agrees on three things:

- The top priority
- The desired outcome
- How success will be measured

Without this clarity, AI efforts have difficulty moving beyond pilot and fail to deliver a return on investment.

2 Readiness To Adopt

> *Is your data posture strong enough to support AI—even imperfectly?*

Next, assess your data posture in practical terms. Module 3 goes deeper into data strategy, but the key questions to ask now are:

- Are core data sources accessible?
- Are they trusted enough to use?
- Are teams willing to improve data quality where needed?

AI does not require perfect data, but it does require intention and a continuous improvement mindset.

3 Change Management Readiness

> *Are your people prepared for AI to change how work flows across the business?*

AI agents will change workflows across the business. The technology is only as effective as the organization's willingness to adapt. Key leadership questions include:

- Are managers prepared to lead adoption?
- Do teams understand AI is assistive—not a replacement?
- Is there a plan to build confidence over time?

Organizations that prepare people early move faster later.

Remember: These three readiness areas—executive alignment, data posture, and change management—are not sequential. They reinforce each other. Weakness in one area will limit the impact of strength in the others.

Tightening the Management Process

AI is not a "set it and forget it" initiative. It requires oversight and review, and it will amplify whatever management discipline already exists—or doesn't exist. Leaders who build strong operational rhythms around AI see compounding returns. Those who don't will find that AI simply surfaces problems faster than the organization can respond.

Four Habits of High-Readiness Organizations

1 Detect Emerging Realities Early

Rather than waiting for problems to escalate, high-readiness teams use AI signals to identify trends while they are still small and manageable—turning reactive firefighting into proactive stewardship.

2 Manage the System as a Whole

Instead of optimizing individual components in isolation, effective leaders look at how changes in one area ripple across the subscriber journey—managing interconnections, not just individual metrics.

3 Respond Quickly to Small Signals

Small signals, caught early, stay contained. Organizations with strong management rhythms act on early indicators before they compound into systemic issues that require far more effort to resolve.

4 Focus on Creating New Value

Rather than simply shifting work between teams, the most effective organizations use AI to create genuine new value—better subscriber experiences, faster resolution, and proactive engagement.

Leadership must set the tone to get the most out of AI. These four habits are not technology practices—they are management practices. AI simply makes them more visible and more consequential.

Key Insight: AI amplifies whatever management discipline already exists. If your leadership rhythms are strong, AI will make them more effective. If gaps exist, AI will make those visible too. Either way, the clarity is a gift.

Chapter Takeaway

AI does not create change on its own. Instead, it quickly reveals where change is needed. The organizations that move fastest are the ones that treat AI as a business initiative—and prepare their teams, data, and processes to support it. Start with executive alignment on a specific business outcome, assess your readiness honestly, and build the management habits that let AI deliver lasting value.

MODULE 2

CHAPTER 7

Getting Started with Agentic AI

Chapter 6 established that AI success is ultimately a leadership and change challenge. This chapter turns that mindset into action: how to get started with agentic AI by aligning it to your business objectives, mapping the KPIs that matter to the right AI capabilities, and building the data discipline that makes every stage of the journey work.

For communication service providers, getting started with agentic AI is less about chasing the newest technology and more about making deliberate choices. The leaders who succeed begin with business objectives, identify the KPIs that matter most, and then map those outcomes to the AI capabilities that can actually move the needle. At every step, clean and connected data is what turns promise into performance. When the information agents rely on is fragmented, inconsistent, or outdated, they don't solve problems — they scale them. When data is accurate, current, and ready to use, agentic AI amplifies good decisions and makes them faster, more consistent, and more confident.

What do we mean by "clean data"? Clean data is accurate, complete, consistently formatted, and up to date. It means subscriber records that reflect reality, knowledge articles that aren't contradictory or stale, and business rules that are documented rather than tribal. Clean data is the difference between an agent that gives a confident, correct answer and one that confidently gives the wrong one.

What You'll Learn

- How data quality requirements evolve across the three stages of the Agentic AI Journey
- Why each stage breaks down without intentional data discipline — and how to prevent it
- How the domain agents for Agent Workforce Cloud are built to improve data quality as they are used
- How to build enrichment habits that support scale before you need them
- Map business objectives and KPIs to the right starting agent

The Agentic AI Journey

The Agentic AI Journey moves through three stages, and each one raises the bar for data quality. Think of it as climbing a staircase: each step up requires stronger data underneath. At the first step, poor data leads to a bad answer — a human catches it and moves on. At the second step, that same bad data triggers a bad action, repeated at automation speed. At the third step, it cascades across agents and departments before anyone notices. Skip the discipline early and you may still get a pilot off the ground — but you will not be able to scale it.

1

Knowledge Assist

Answer This Question

Agents enable your marketing, support, and operations teams to find answers more quickly and learn faster. Instead of searching through outdated documents or waiting for a colleague, employees ask and get an immediate, grounded answer.

Data Enrichment
When knowledge sources are accurate and current, agents deliver consistent answers. Every thumbs-up/down interaction surfaces gaps and drives continuous improvement.

Employee Experience
Teams stop searching and start asking. New hires ramp faster. Experienced staff spend less time answering the same questions repeatedly.

FOUNDATION

2

Task Automation

Do This Task

Agents carry out tasks to meet defined goals and rules — to resolve issues, build segments, and trigger workflows — improving speed of execution and leveraging insights from past interactions.

Data Enrichment
When historical data is clean and rules are well defined, agents resolve issues correctly the first time. Each resolved interaction becomes training data.

Employee Experience
Repetitive, low-judgment tasks are handled by agents. Staff focus on exceptions, escalations, and work that requires human judgment.

AUTOMATED

3

Process Orchestration

Run This Process

Agents react to events, anticipate needs, and coordinate with other agents to complete complex tasks autonomously — across departments, systems, and workflows.

Data Enrichment
When data definitions are consistent across domains, agents hand off cleanly to one another — enabling fully autonomous cross-system workflows.

Employee Experience
Staff shift from executing processes to overseeing them. They intervene on exceptions. Agents handle the rest.

ENTERPRISE-SCALE

Key Point: The organizations that invest in data quality habits at Stage 1 are the ones that will be ready to operate at enterprise scale by Stage 3. Those that wait will find themselves rebuilding foundations under pressure.

Knowledge Enrichment

On Day 1 of any agent implementation, your knowledge base is at its weakest. This is not a failure — it is how agent systems work. They are designed to learn and improve through use, but only when they are fed accurate, current, and well-structured knowledge. Without intentional enrichment, agents learn faster from outdated information, amplifying the very problems you hoped they would solve.

Key Insight: Think of knowledge enrichment not as a one-time cleanup project, but as an ongoing discipline — like maintaining a garden. The work is never done, but the rewards grow with each passing season.

Effective Enrichment Practices

Building a sustainable knowledge enrichment process does not require massive infrastructure or specialized teams. It requires commitment to a handful of simple, repeatable practices that prevent confusion from creeping back in and ensure agent outputs remain credible as usage expands.

1

Clear Ownership of Key Data Domains

Assign named owners for each critical knowledge area. When everyone is responsible, no one is responsible. Ownership creates accountability and ensures someone is actively watching for drift.

2

Simple Naming and Documentation Standards

Establish consistent conventions so that knowledge articles, data fields, and processes are easy to find and understand. Complexity is the enemy of adoption.

3

Lightweight Monthly or Quarterly Review Cadence

Schedule regular check-ins to verify accuracy, retire outdated content, and surface gaps. A short, recurring review beats an annual overhaul every time.

4

Freshness Dates and Archiving Policies

Tag content with "last verified" dates and set clear rules for when material should be reviewed, updated, or removed. Stale information is worse than no information—it erodes trust.

Aligning AI to Your Business Objectives

With multiple agentic workflows available, strong leaders don't start by asking which features are ready — they start with business priorities. The goal is to find the intersection of where your organization most needs to improve, where the data already supports action, and where your teams are ready to move.

1
STEP

Start with Business Priorities

Ground your conversation in financial reality. Where is cost highest? Where is revenue most constrained? Where do manual processes consume the most labor? Agentic AI should tie directly to lines on the P&L — not exist as a technology project in isolation.

ASK YOUR LEADERSHIP TEAM

- → How are we measuring success today?
- → What is our top priority this year?

2
STEP

Identify the KPI That Matters Most

Once you've located the business pressure point, name the specific metric. Is it subscriber churn rate? Mean time to repair? Cost per truck roll? Marketing conversion rate? A sharp KPI gives your agentic initiative a clear target — and makes it easy to demonstrate progress to your board and executive team.

ASK YOUR LEADERSHIP TEAM

- → Where does performance tend to drift?
- → When something goes wrong, how quickly do we know and act?

3
STEP

Map the AI Capability That Can Influence It

With a KPI in hand, work backward to identify which agent or combination of agents can realistically move that number. This step should involve both your AI leadership team and operational leads — it bridges strategy and execution, ensuring the capability you deploy is connected to the outcome you're chasing.

ASK YOUR LEADERSHIP TEAM

- → Which agents align to this KPI?
- → Is our data ready enough to act — or close to it?

Chapter Takeaway

Data quality is one of the few levers every organization can fully control. Agentic AI — from Knowledge Assist to Task Automation to Process Orchestration — only delivers its promise when data quality keeps pace at every stage. Treat knowledge enrichment as an ongoing leadership discipline, not a technical chore, and each stage of agent maturity will compound the last.

In the next chapter, we will explore how to measure AI progress and demonstrate ROI — giving your leadership team the evidence it needs to sustain momentum and justify continued investment.

MODULE 2

CHAPTER 8

Where To Start With Calix Agent Workforce Cloud

With trust established through disciplined data practices, it's time to put your agents to work — deliberately and where they'll matter most.

Agent Workforce Cloud is a force multiplier that allows leaders to execute intent at scale, not team by team. By coordinating decisions and actions end-to-end, Agent Workforce Cloud turns trusted data into sustained performance that is faster, earlier, and more consistent than traditional operating models can deliver. In this chapter, you'll learn which agents are available to you, how they work together, and how to identify the right place to start for maximum momentum.

What You'll Learn

- Describe the role of AI agents in broadband operations
- Recognize the primary categories of Agent Workforce Cloud

The Calix AI Strategy

01
CREATE HIGH-TRUST JUDGMENT
Develop AI systems that can make decisions and recommendations in a way that earns and sustains human trust.

02
FOCUS ON STRATEGIC IMPACT
Deliver new AI-driven efficiencies for service providers' business, operations, support, and engagement.

03
ENHANCE SUBSCRIBER EXPERIENCES
Enable broadband experience providers to quickly evolve, disrupt, and compete with any service provider.

End-to-End Agentic Platform Purpose Built for CSPs

Meet Your Agent Workforce Cloud

Imagine having an infinite number of knowledgeable employees working seamlessly 24x7 on behalf of you and your customers. That's the promise of Calix Agent Workforce Cloud — not a collection of isolated tools, but a coordinated system of agents that share context, hand off decisions, and act in the best interest of the subscriber at every turn.

Agent Workforce Cloud brings together agents aligned to key functions within the broadband business, each focused on a distinct set of outcomes. While every agent group has deep functional expertise, they deliver the greatest value when operating as a connected team that acts proactively, consistently, and in the best interest of the customer.

Domain Agents

Knowledge assist and task automation within Engagement, Operations, and Service Cloud

MARKETING AGENT · OPERATIONS AGENT · SERVICE AGENT · SUBSCRIBER AGENT

Agent-to-Agent

COMING SOON

Business process workflow automation with cross-domain agent-to-agent orchestration

CAMPAIGN BUILDER · CROSS-SELL & UPSELL · OUTAGE MANAGEMENT · CHURN PREVENTION

ENGAGEMENT CLOUD

Marketing Agent

Equip marketers with accurate, grounded answers and guided help to accelerate adoption and execution.

Key Capabilities

- Answers feature, KPI, and filter definition questions and how-to queries
- Starter prompts help new marketers get moving quickly
- Responses grounded in approved documents — no invented answers
- Allows upload of BSP-specific knowledge
- Thumbs-up/down feedback loop continuously improves the knowledge base

OPERATIONS CLOUD

Operations Agent

Help Operations team members answer questions on systems, processes, and the network to assist in troubleshooting and testing.

Key Capabilities

- Runs natively within Calix Operations Cloud
- Leverages Cloud knowledgebase content and BSP-uploaded documentation
- Natural language prompts replace complex search queries
- Thumbs-up/down feedback loop drives continuous improvement

SERVICE CLOUD

Service Agent

Boost CSR expertise and productivity with contextually specific answers to accelerate resolution and increase subscriber loyalty.

Key Capabilities

- Domain-based AI agent delivers contextually specific, guardrailed answers
- Upload your own knowledge articles for continuous enrichment
- Thumbs-up/down feedback loop improves accuracy over time
- Natural language prompts simplify the CSR experience
- Guardrails prevent hallucinations and out-of-scope responses

COMMANDIQ

Subscriber Agent

Put every subscriber in charge of their experience with plain-language conversation, smart routines, and timely recommendations for a truly personal journey.

Key Capabilities

- Knowledge Assist delivers conversational answers to "how do I…" questions
- Automation executes "do this for me…" commands through natural language
- Accepts plain text or spoken voice input for hands-free interaction
- Personalizes routines, protections, and experiences for every household
- Recommends timely upgrades for a truly personal subscriber journey

Real-World Agentic AI Examples

The following examples illustrate how agentic capabilities translate leadership intent into coordinated action across the business. Each scenario shows how decisions that typically span multiple teams can be detected earlier, executed faster, and managed end-to-end when context is shared and accountability is clear.

The result is not incremental efficiency — it's materially better outcomes delivered at scale. Notice in each example how the agents work in sequence, building on each other's context rather than operating in isolation.

SCENARIO 01

Reducing Churn Through Proactive, Personalized Offers

SIGNAL

The **Operations Agent** detects early churn indicators — network degradation, usage decline, and recent service friction — surfacing at-risk households before they call or cancel.

DECISION

The **Subscriber Agent** identifies the household values reliability over price. The **Service Agent** confirms unresolved friction. The **Marketing Agent** selects an experience-based retention offer — not a discount.

ACTION

A leader approves the recommendation. Agents coordinate execution across the subscriber's preferred channel, schedule a follow-up, and begin ongoing experience monitoring.

OUTCOME

Churn Rate in Above the Line Revenue decreases because at-risk subscribers are identified and retained before they cancel. Earlier and more personalized intervention improves **retention over time,** which increases **subscriber lifetime value** and supports more stable revenue growth across the install base.

SCENARIO 02

Proactive Service Notification and Repair

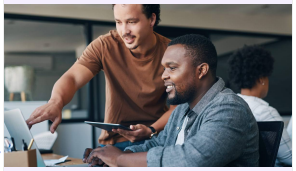
SIGNAL

The **Operations Agent** detects a network outage, classifies severity, and escalates with full context — affected subscriber count, scope, and estimated impact — before a single inbound call arrives.

DECISION

The **Service Agent** assesses customer impact. The **Subscriber** and **Marketing Agents** determine the right communication channel for each household — prioritizing those most at risk of frustration.

ACTION



Proactive notifications go out before subscribers notice the issue. A leader authorizes field dispatch with full context in hand. Upon restoration, agents automatically trigger service-restored communications.

OUTCOME

Cost per Call and Call-In Rate in Above the Line COGS for Customer Support decrease because proactive communication reduces inbound support volume. Faster resolution and clear updates improve **First Call Resolution** and strengthen subscriber trust, which lowers support costs and helps prevent revenue loss from churn.

In both scenarios, the key differentiator is not any single agent — it's the handoff. Each agent passes enriched context to the next, so decisions are made with the full picture rather than a fragment. This is what separates agentic AI from simple automation: not just speed, but coordinated intelligence operating with shared purpose.

Chapter Takeaway

The Calix AI strategy — built on high-trust judgment, strategic impact, and subscriber experience — is delivered through an end-to-end agentic platform purpose-built for CSPs. On top of that platform, the Agent Workforce Cloud puts Marketing, Operations, Service, and Subscriber agents to work 24×7 across your business, and the real-world agentic AI examples in this chapter show how they come together to drive measurable outcomes. When strategy, platform, and agents align, AI stops being a technology project and becomes an operating advantage.

MODULE 3

INTRODUCTION

Growing AI Capabilities

Modules 1 and 2 established two critical foundations. First, AI is not simply another technology cycle: it represents a shift in how work gets done and how organizations operate. Second, successful AI adoption depends far more on leadership alignment, data discipline, governance, and organizational readiness than on tools alone.

Module 3 looks ahead. The question is no longer whether AI will influence your organization, but how leaders guide their teams as AI capabilities continue to grow. This module focuses on the leadership mindset required to scale AI responsibly, build trust over time, and prepare the organization for a future where AI systems and people work together.

What You Will Learn

- Understand the evolving role of leadership in the AI era
- Establish the right pace for responsible AI adoption
- Build accountability and governance into AI systems
- Prepare your organization for AI-driven operations
- Strengthen long-term readiness through disciplined execution

Chapters in This Module

CHAPTER 9

Go Slow to Go Fast

Why thoughtful pacing and trust-building accelerate AI adoption over time.

CHAPTER 10

Governance and Accountability

Building the structures that ensure AI systems operate within clear, trusted boundaries.

CHAPTER 11

Leading for the Long Term

Sustaining AI momentum through continuous learning and disciplined execution.

What Success Looks Like

Organizations that successfully scale AI over time usually demonstrate five leadership behaviors:

1. **AI is treated as a strategic capability, not a one-time initiative**
2. **Governance and accountability are explicit and enforced**
3. **Teams understand how AI supports their work**
4. **AI systems operate within transparent, trusted boundaries**
5. **Continuous learning becomes part of everyday management**

> *These organizations do not move recklessly. They move deliberately and build confidence as they go.*

MODULE 3

CHAPTER 9

Go Slow To Go Fast

As AI begins influencing decisions at scale, speed without discipline becomes risk.

Earlier automation efforts followed fixed rules established by users. Modern AI recognizes patterns, interprets context, and generates recommendations that can shape outcomes across the business. That expanded capability is what makes AI valuable—and what requires a different leadership approach. The most effective leaders follow a simple principle: Move deliberately at first so the organization can scale with confidence later.

What You'll Learn

- Understand why AI adoption requires thoughtful pacing
- Establish the right leadership mindset for scaling AI
- Build accountability and evaluation into AI operations

Agents Are Part of the Workforce

As AI capabilities grow, organizations are beginning to treat AI agents as a new category of workforce participant. These agents can operate around the clock to support employees and customers: monitoring signals, initiating workflows, and escalating exceptions to human owners when needed. Even as these capabilities expand and become more powerful, responsibility for outcomes remains with leadership.

In practical terms, this means leaders must treat AI systems with the same seriousness as any other operational resource.

Leadership Imperative: To make this real for teams, leaders must define a clear operating model for agents—what they are allowed to do, what requires approval, how exceptions are handled, and who remains accountable for outcomes.

4 Roles for Agentic Workflows: A Practical Guide

As AI agents become part of everyday operations, leaders must define a clear operating model that makes accountability visible.

ROLE 1 · EXECUTION

AI Agent

Monitors signals, recommends or initiates actions within defined boundaries — operating continuously across the business.

ROLE 2 · REVIEW

Human Operator

Approves, overrides, or investigates exceptions. The human judgment layer between automation and outcome.

ROLE 3 · ACCOUNTABILITY

Process Owner

Accountable for outcomes and overall workflow performance — regardless of who, or what, executes each step.

ROLE 4 · OVERSIGHT

Governance Lead

Ensures compliance, auditability, and controls are functioning across all AI operations.

Trust Is the Real Output of Data Quality

Agents don't fail because they lack capability. They fail when they are not trustworthy. As more employees and subscribers interact with agents, they are each asking themselves a set of critical questions — and how they answer those questions will determine whether your agent investments succeed or stall.

Trust is built on data quality. When the information agents rely on is incomplete, outdated, or inconsistent, they don't solve problems — they scale confusion. When data is accurate, current, and connected, agents become reliable partners that teams are willing to act on.

Ask Yourself — and Your Team

These are the questions your employees and subscribers are already asking. How you answer them will determine whether agent adoption succeeds or stalls.

1. *"Do I trust this agent to give me an accurate and reliable answer?"*
   If the underlying knowledge is wrong, the answer will be wrong — and people will stop asking.
2. *"Do I trust that this recommendation is based on complete and current information?"*
   Agents are only as current as the data they draw from. Stale knowledge produces stale guidance — at scale.
3. *"Do I trust that this agent is working from the same reality I am?"*
   When employees and agents operate from different versions of the truth, coordination breaks down. Shared, enriched knowledge is what keeps everyone aligned.
4. *"Do I trust that I can reach a human if something goes wrong?"*
   Even the best agent needs a clear escalation path. Confidence in automation grows when people know the safety net exists.

> **Trust is the threshold** at which data quality becomes a leadership issue rather than a technical one. Without it, agents remain confined to pilots. With it, they scale.

Why Cross-Functional Orchestration Raises the Stakes

As agents move from answering questions to executing tasks to orchestrating workflows, the consequence of poor data quality shifts dramatically. At Stage 1, a bad data point leads to a bad answer — a human catches it and moves on. At Stage 2, that same bad data point leads to a bad action, repeated across hundreds of transactions. At Stage 3, it cascades across agents, systems, and departments before anyone notices.

💡

KNOWLEDGE ASSIST STAGE

Missed Opportunities

Poor data leads to incomplete answers that erode trust and slow adoption before agents can prove their value.

→

⚠️

TASK AUTOMATION STAGE

Eroded Confidence

Inconsistent outputs from stale rules or data reduce team willingness to delegate tasks to agents, stalling adoption.

→

🔴

ORCHESTRATION STAGE

Scaled Operational Risk

Cross-agent workflows amplify data errors at enterprise speed, with limited human review to catch mistakes before they cascade.

> **Key Insight:** The best time to build data discipline is before you need it for orchestration. The organizations that invest in these habits early will be the ones ready to scale when the technology matures.

How Leadership Roles Evolve in the AI Era

When AI agents recommend actions, initiate workflows, and surface risks earlier, leaders must shift from managing activity to governing decision systems. The work of leadership must deliberately shape how decisions are made, reviewed, and improved.

What AI-Era Leaders Do in Practice

1. **Set clear decision boundaries**
   Leaders explicitly define which decisions AI may recommend, initiate, or escalate — and which remain human-led.
2. **Establish approval thresholds**
   Human oversight is designed into the system, with clear criteria for when review is required and when automation is appropriate.

3 **Own outcomes end-to-end**

Accountability never shifts to the AI agent. Leaders remain responsible for results, even when AI influences the decision.

4 **Run continuous knowledge enrichment loops**

Accuracy, adoption, exceptions, and outcomes are reviewed as part of normal operating cadence — enabling steady improvement over time.

💡 EXAMPLE IN PRACTICE

Customer Support Leadership in the AI Era

A Customer Support leader no longer waits for escalations. They define which issues are best suited for autonomous AI agents, which require a human in the loop, and how overall performance is managed to strengthen workflows and improve trust.

Key Insight: AI-era leaders intentionally shape decision environments, build confidence and trust through transparency, and treat knowledge enrichment as a core management discipline.

Chapter Takeaway

AI adoption does not reward organizations that move recklessly. It rewards organizations that move thoughtfully and build trust as they scale.

The goal is not speed alone. The goal is sustainable capability.

MODULE 3

CHAPTER 10

AI Governance Goes Mainstream

As AI capabilities expand, governance can no longer be treated as a technical or IT-led concern.

When AI is part of every workstream, AI governance has to go mainstream. How decisions are made, how accountability is maintained, and how company values are reflected as AI becomes embedded in normal operations must be designed into leadership behavior — ensuring AI becomes a trusted capability rather than a source of risk.

What You'll Learn

- Understand why AI governance must become part of everyday leadership
- Protect privacy, security, and trust as AI capabilities grow
- Define accountability for AI-driven decisions

AI Is Becoming Part of Everyday Digital Life

Subscribers will find it impossible to separate AI from their daily digital experiences. As fiber connectivity enables AI-powered tools across work, home, and entertainment, the expectations for speed, personalization, and support continue to rise. Those expectations have a direct impact on service providers.

CSPs sit at the center of this shift because they power the connectivity that makes these experiences possible. With that position comes responsibility. Providers must ensure that the AI systems supporting their operations protect customer privacy, operate securely, and deliver reliable, trustworthy experiences at scale.

Accountability Is a Leadership Discipline

Effective leaders recognize and avoid **accountability laundering** — the temptation to shift responsibility to "what the AI recommended." If an AI-assisted decision results in harm, poor performance, or a degraded customer experience, accountability remains with leadership.

To prevent this, AI systems must operate within clear oversight structures that leaders actively define and govern.

AI may support decisions.
Organizations remain responsible for the results.

Accountability Enables Trust at Scale

Trust in AI systems begins with data quality, but it is sustained through transparency and governance. Organizations that scale AI responsibly embed three capabilities directly into how their systems operate.

CAPABILITY 1

Accountability

Clear ownership of decisions and outcomes, with leaders explicitly responsible for performance — not the systems they use.

CAPABILITY 2

Traceability

The ability to understand how recommendations were produced and what inputs influenced them — so decisions can be explained.

CAPABILITY 3

Auditability

The ability to review decisions and outcomes over time — so leaders can detect failures early, investigate root causes, and correct course quickly.

Key Insight: Together, these three capabilities allow organizations to move deliberately without slowing innovation. They ensure AI operates within trusted boundaries while giving leaders the confidence to scale.

Chapter Takeaway

AI governance is not a side project.

It is a leadership responsibility that protects trust, ensures accountability, and supports long-term innovation.

MODULE 3

CHAPTER 11

Organizational Readiness and the Path Forward

No organization is ever fully ready to implement AI.

Readiness is not a prerequisite — it is an outcome. AI capability is built through action, learning, and disciplined leadership over time. Organizations that wait for perfect data or complete certainty rarely move beyond pilots. Those that make progress start where they are and improve through use.

What You'll Learn

- Understand why AI readiness is developed through execution, not preparation alone
- Assess where your organization sits on the AI maturity curve
- Build momentum by leveraging existing strengths rather than fixing everything at once
- Lead adoption realistically by addressing uncertainty and resistance
- Establish a practical path forward where people and AI work together — starting now

The Three Levels of AI Maturity

Organizations progress through AI maturity in stages. These are not gates to clear before starting. They are patterns that emerge as leadership, governance, and data discipline improve.

LEVEL 1
Exploration
Teams experiment with AI tools in advisory roles, building familiarity, confidence, and shared language.

LEVEL 2
Operational Activation
AI supports real workflows with human approval. Governance becomes practical and outcomes become measurable.

LEVEL 3
Scaled Intelligence
Multiple AI agents work as a coordinated workforce, escalating exceptions to named human owners.

Progress Is Built by Doing

Movement between maturity levels does not happen by design alone. It happens when leaders are willing to start with what is available and improve through execution. Here are signs that you are on the right path.

SIGNS OF PROGRESS
From Exploration to Operational Activation

- Data quality standards are defined and improving
- Minimum governance expectations are in place
- At least one workflow delivers measurable outcomes

SIGNS OF PROGRESS
From Operational Activation to Scaled Intelligence

- Multiple workflows are supported by AI agents
- Monitoring and audit coverage are in place
- Escalation paths and exception handling are clear

- Leaders are explicitly assigned ownership roles
- Adoption and trust metrics trend positively

The Best Time To Start

The best time to start was last year.
The second-best time is today.

AI adoption does not happen overnight. It requires leadership attention, organizational learning, and steady improvement. Organizations that begin now are far better positioned as AI capabilities continue to evolve.

> **Key Insight:** Waiting for certainty delays learning. Starting builds it.

Chapter Takeaway

AI maturity is not achieved through perfect readiness. It is built through leadership discipline, learning by doing, and consistent execution.

Leadership does not wait for readiness. Leadership creates it.

SELF-ASSESSMENT TOOL

INTERACTIVE ASSESSMENT

AI-Ready Leader Strengths & Opportunities Finder

Rate your organization honestly across seven domains. Tailored recommendations appear in real time on the right as you complete each section.

Instructions

Based on current reality, rate each statement on a scale of 1 to 5. Answer based on your **current reality**, not where you want to be.

1 Not in place | 2 Limited / inconsistent | 3 Partially in place | 4 Mostly in place | 5 Fully in place and consistent

FOCUS AND VALUE

1 Business Alignment & Use-Case Focus

Ensure AI efforts are anchored to a single, leadership-aligned business priority by identifying where performance breaks down across the end-to-end subscriber journey and committing to a clearly owned, outcome-driven use case.

1. We have identified the highest-impact business outcome to improve and the specific performance breakdown(s) across the end-to-end subscriber journey that AI should address first. 1 2 3 4 5

2. Leadership has selected a single priority AI initiative/use case and can clearly explain why it matters now, who owns it, and how success will be measured. 1 2 3 4 5

3. AI efforts are treated as business initiatives tied to measurable outcomes (not "pilot-for-pilot's-sake"), with a clear decision to scale, iterate, or stop. 1 2 3 4 5

2 Value Measurement & Outcomes

Confirm the organization can define meaningful outcome metrics, review AI impact through an active management cadence, and use those signals to decide when to continue, adjust, or stop AI initiatives.

4. For the priority AI initiative, we have defined outcome metrics that tie directly to operational and subscriber value (not just activity or output metrics). 1 2 3 4 5

5. We track impact in a way that enables leadership decisions (continue / adjust / stop) and can communicate results credibly across stakeholders. 1 2 3 4 5

6. We have an operating cadence to review outcomes, exceptions, and adoption signals—so we detect issues early and improve the workflow over time. 1 2 3 4 5

TRUST & GOVERNANCE

3 Data Foundation, Trust & Enrichment

Assess whether the organization has accessible, well-owned data and knowledge sources supported by ongoing enrichment practices that sustain trust as AI usage expands.

7. We know which data and knowledge sources are required for the priority AI initiative and where they live across the organization. 1 2 3 4 5

8. Core data/knowledge sources are accessible in the environments where AI will be used, within existing security boundaries. 1 2 3 4 5

9. We have clear ownership and a lightweight knowledge/data enrichment process (freshness, curation cadence, standards) to sustain trust as AI usage scales. 1 2 3 4 5

4 Governance & Ownership

Establish clear leadership accountability for AI-influenced decisions by defining human-in-the-loop boundaries, escalation paths, and the traceability needed to govern outcomes responsibly at scale.

10. Named leaders own AI-influenced decisions end-to-end, and accountability does not shift to "what the AI recommended." 1 2 3 4 5

11. Human-in-the-loop rules are defined (what AI may recommend/trigger, what requires approval, and how exceptions are escalated). 1 2 3 4 5

12. AI operations are traceable and auditable (we can review inputs, decisions, and outcomes, and can intervene/rollback when needed). 1 2 3 4 5

5 Operating Model, Decision Systems & Scalability

Determine whether the organization has a clear operating model for AI; defining where AI lives, how risk is governed, and how agentic workflows move reliably from pilot to repeatable production.

13. We have decided where AI will "live" (trusted SaaS, data/analytics layer, or custom/agent systems) and have matched governance intensity to that risk level. 1 2 3 4 5

YOUR RESULTS

STRENGTH BY DOMAIN

1. Biz Align 0/15
2. Value Meas. 0/15
3. Data Found. 0/15
4. Governance 0/15
5. Op. Model 0/15
6. Workforce 0/15
7. Change 0/15

RECOMMENDATIONS

Complete any domain to see tailored recommendations based on your score mix.

✉ Email My Results

↺ Reset Assessment

14. Our operating model explicitly defines four roles for AI workflows: agent, human operator, process owner, and governance lead. 1 2 3 4 5

15. We can move from pilot to production with repeatable patterns (security, change, adoption, measurement) rather than one-off implementations. 1 2 3 4 5

ADOPTION & SUSTAINED CHANGE

6 Workforce Readiness & Adoption

Evaluate whether employees and managers are prepared to adopt AI in real workflows through role-based enablement, hands-on application, and leadership behaviors that build confidence over time.

16. Employees understand how AI assists their role and have practical opportunities to apply it in daily workflows (not just awareness training). 1 2 3 4 5

17. Managers are equipped to lead adoption: addressing resistance with empathy/evidence and reinforcing how AI changes workflows. 1 2 3 4 5

18. We have an enablement approach matched to personas/roles (microlearning, peer-led support, and partner resources) and we track progress. 1 2 3 4 5

7 Change, Culture & Responsible Scaling

Measure the organization's ability to lead AI as a sustained change initiative by fostering psychological safety, learning from experimentation, and pacing adoption deliberately to build trust before scaling automation.

19. We have a clear change plan with coalition/champion support and a communication cadence that consistently reinforces "why," progress, and expectations. 1 2 3 4 5

20. Teams feel safe surfacing concerns and exceptions, and leaders treat those signals as learning inputs to improve systems (not as blame). 1 2 3 4 5

21. We pace adoption deliberately ("go slow to go fast"), increasing automation only as trust, controls, and readiness mature. 1 2 3 4 5

TAKE IT OFFLINE

Administer This Assessment in Person

Prefer to run this as a group session or hand it out to your leadership team? Download the printable version to facilitate the assessment offline.

Download Printable PDF

AI LEADERSHIP PLAYBOOK

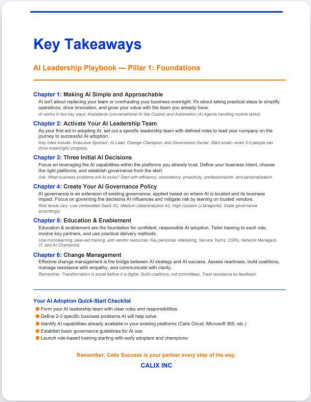
Thank You for Exploring This Playbook

You've taken the first step toward AI leadership. Now it's time to put these insights into action.

Printable Action Items for AI Adoption & Success

Your essential roadmap for implementing AI with confidence and clarity. Download this quick-reference guide to keep the key takeaways at your fingertips.

- ✓ Quick-reference format for easy implementation
- ✓ Actionable steps you can start using today
- ✓ Key takeaways from all six chapters



Key Takeaways

AI Leadership Playbook — Pillar 1: Foundations

Chapter 1: Making AI Simple and Approachable
AI isn't about replacing your team or overhauling your business overnight. It's about taking practical steps to simplify operations, drive innovation, and grow your value with the team you already have.
AI exists in two key ways: Assistance (conversational AI like Copilot) and Automation (AI Agents handling routine tasks).

Chapter 2: Activate Your AI Leadership Team
As your first act in adopting AI, set out a specific leadership team with defined roles to lead your company on the journey to successful AI adoption.
Key roles include: Sponsor, AI Lead, Change Champion, and Governance Owner. Start small—even 2-3 people can drive meaningful progress.

Chapter 3: Three Initial AI Decisions
Focus on leveraging the AI capabilities within the platforms you already trust. Define your business intent, choose the right solutions, and establish governance from the start.
Key AI capabilities include: Conversational AI, Automation, Analytics, consistency, proactivity, professionalism, and personalization.

Chapter 4: Create Your AI Governance Policy
AI governance is an extension of existing governance, applied based on where AI is located and its business impact. Focus on governing the decisions AI influences and mitigate risk by leaning on trusted vendors.
Risk levels vary: Low (embedded SaaS AI), Medium (data/analytics AI), High (custom LLM/agents). Scale governance accordingly.

Chapter 5: Education & Enablement
Education & enablement are the foundation for confident, responsible AI adoption. Tailor training to each role, involve key partners, and use practical delivery methods.
Key methods: role-based training, and vendor resources. Key personas: Marketing, Service Techs, CSRs, Network Managers, IT, and AI Champions.

Chapter 6: Change Management
Effective change management is the bridge between AI strategy and AI success. Assess readiness, build coalitions, manage resistance with empathy, and communicate with clarity.
Remember: Transformation is social before it is digital. Build coalitions, not committees. Treat resistance as feedback.

Your AI Adoption Quick-Start Checklist

- ☐ Form your AI leadership team with clear roles and responsibilities
- ☐ Define 2-3 specific business problems AI will help solve
- ☐ Identify AI capabilities already available in your existing platforms (Calix Cloud, Microsoft 365, etc.)
- ☐ Establish basic governance guidelines for AI use
- ☐ Launch role-based training starting with early adopters and champions

Remember: Calix Success is your partner every step of the way.

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